confident, beaming women who walked with their heads held high, holding Rahul ji's hand, hugging him, blessing him, walking with him, expressing themselves and proving that when men provide a comfortable and safe space for women to thrive, to speak, to voice and to sing, women create miracles.

There were women from across the social spectrum and across all age groups, who wore different clothes and spoke different languages, who prayed differently, and cooked and ate different kinds of food—but they were united in their need to be heard, counted and treated as partners and not merely gender-representative ornamental ticks in boxes.

I walked for some days in the Yatra across different states and saw people from a close range as they marched along. They walked with a sense of purpose, their steps in solidarity for something above and beyond the immediate. I was awestruck at how they erupted with joy upon meeting Rahul ji. Some of them were so overwhelmed by emotion that they burst into tears, and it struck me how Rahul ji repeatedly put them at ease. How empathetic he was with people who met him. He greeted each one of them warmly, made them feel special. He never stopped smiling and never wore a frown, even when he sometimes winced in pain.

Here was a leader who was walking across the country listening to people, their concerns and their stories. He made them feel seen, heard and spoken of. He emphasized the need to listen in the twenty-first century—listen to collective and individual aspirations, to challenges and conquests, and to people, so that the path ahead could be paved with their feedback, and policy formation be focused and directed towards addressing what people needed.

From a distance, the Yatra looked noisy. There were people all around, there was loud cheering. People wanted to be heard. They were trying to attract Rahul ji's attention, but in the din it was absolutely quiet. There was a sense of profound stillness and calm around Rahul Gandhi, a sense of silence amid the chaos on the surface—a space that allowed conversations to flourish. The side of Rahul Gandhi that I saw in the Yatra was one where he had risen above being an individual and above being a politician in